

Title

A Community Venue-Based HIV Prevention Initiative Targeting Men: Protocol for Assessing Feasibility, Acceptability, and Preliminary Effectiveness in a Sub-Saharan African Setting

Abstract

Men in high-transmission settings show low engagement with conventional HIV prevention services. Non-traditional community venues may offer opportunities for outreach and behavior change support. This protocol describes a cluster-randomized trial evaluating a barbershop-based HIV prevention program in a high-transmission district in Uganda. Approximately 250 men frequenting participating barbershops will be enrolled and followed for 12 months. Barbershops will be randomly assigned to either the intervention program (including HIV education delivered by trained barbers, free self-testing kits, and peer-support discussion groups) or standard care. Primary outcomes include program feasibility metrics (reach, attendance, session fidelity) and participant-reported acceptability. Secondary outcomes include self-reported HIV testing completion, changes in sexual risk behaviors, and interest in or use of biomedical prevention services. Exploratory outcomes include incident sexually transmitted infections. Data will be collected through participant surveys, clinical specimens, and implementation metrics at baseline, 6 months, and 12 months.